

YOUNG AUTHOR'S GUIDE

How to Write Amazing Stories, Poems & More (Ages 8-14)

15 Chapters * Techniques * Exercises * 30-Day Writing Challenge

By Daniel Tesfamariam

YOUNG AUTHOR'S GUIDE

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

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CHAPTER 1

Every Kid Is a Writer

Yes, YOU are a writer! If you can think, imagine, and feel, you can write. Writing is not about being perfect - it is about expressing YOUR unique ideas and voice. Every published author started exactly where you are now. Some wrote terrible first drafts! The secret is simply this: writers WRITE. The more you write, the better you get.

CHAPTER 1: WRITING EXERCISE

Write for 5 minutes without stopping. Don't erase anything. Don't judge. Just WRITE whatever comes to mind. This is called 'freewriting' and it's how professional authors warm up.

YOUR WRITING SPACE:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

CHAPTER 2

Finding Story Ideas

Ideas are everywhere! Look at the world around you and ask 'What if?' What if your pet could talk? What if gravity reversed for a day? What if you found a time machine? Keep an idea journal and write down EVERYTHING - overheard conversations, interesting people, weird dreams, news stories. You will never run out of ideas!

CHAPTER 2: WRITING EXERCISE

Choose one of these 'What If' prompts and write the opening paragraph:

Write from the perspective of your pet for one day.

YOUR WRITING SPACE:

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CHAPTER 3

Building Characters

Great characters feel REAL. They have wants, fears, flaws, strengths, and secrets. Create a character sheet: name, age, appearance, personality, biggest fear, greatest wish, secret, best friend, worst habit, and special talent. The more you know about your character, the more alive they become on the page.

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CHAPTER 4

Creating Settings

Settings are not just locations - they create MOOD. A dark forest feels different from a sunny beach. Use all 5 senses to describe settings: what do characters see, hear, smell, touch, and taste? Make settings come alive so readers feel like they are THERE. The best settings almost become characters themselves.

HEAR (sounds)? SMELL? FEEL (textures)? Can you TASTE anything? Make a reader feel PRESENT.

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CHAPTER 5

Plot Structure

Every great story has a Beginning (introduce characters and world), Middle (problem gets worse, characters struggle), and End (climax and resolution). Think of plot like a roller coaster: it goes up (tension builds), reaches the peak (most exciting moment), then comes down (resolution). Readers need all three parts!

CHAPTER 6

Dialogue That Sounds Real

Good dialogue sounds like how people actually talk - not how they write!

Use contractions (don't instead of do not). Keep speeches short. Give each character a unique voice. Use dialogue to reveal personality, advance the plot, and create tension. Read your dialogue out loud - if it sounds stiff, rewrite it.

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CHAPTER 7

Show, Don't Tell

Instead of telling readers 'Sara was scared,' SHOW it: 'Sara's hands trembled. Her breath came in short gasps. Every shadow looked like a monster.' Showing uses sensory details and actions to make readers FEEL the emotion instead of just being told about it. This is the most powerful writing technique!

CHAPTER 7: WRITING EXERCISE

Rewrite these 'telling' sentences using 'showing': 'It was cold.' 'She was happy.' 'He was tired.' 'The food was delicious.' Use sensory details and actions!

YOUR WRITING SPACE:

[illegible]

CHAPTER 8

Writing Poetry

Poetry is concentrated emotion! You don't need to rhyme (free verse is great!). Poetry types: Haiku (5-7-5 syllables), Acrostic (first letters spell a word), Limerick (funny, AABBA rhyme), Free Verse (no rules!), and Concrete (shaped like the subject). Poetry lets you play with language like an artist plays with paint.

CHAPTER 9

Writing Funny Stories

Humor in writing comes from surprise, exaggeration, weird comparisons, timing, and absurd situations. Funny characters often take things too literally, have extreme reactions, or find themselves in ridiculous situations. Read funny books to learn techniques! And remember: comedy is harder than drama - respect the funny writers.

CHAPTER 9: WRITING EXERCISE

Write a short scene where something embarrassing happens to your character. Make the reader laugh! Use exaggeration and surprise.

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CHAPTER 10

Writing Mysteries

Mystery readers love clues! Plant 'breadcrumbs' throughout your story that make sense looking back. Include red herrings (false clues that mislead). Use misdirection - make readers suspect the wrong person. The solution should be surprising yet logical. Give readers a fair chance to solve it themselves!

CHAPTER 11

Writing Fantasy & Sci-Fi

World-building is the key to great fantasy and sci-fi! Create consistent rules for your world. What is possible and impossible? What is the history? What are the cultures? Great speculative fiction uses impossible settings to explore very REAL human emotions and problems. Even dragons need believable motivations!

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CHAPTER 12

Editing Your Work

First drafts are supposed to be messy - that is why they are called 'rough' drafts! Editing is where good writing becomes GREAT. Steps: 1) Let it rest 24+ hours. 2) Read out loud. 3) Cut unnecessary words. 4) Check for clarity. 5) Fix grammar/spelling. 6) Get feedback. 7) Revise again. Professional authors often edit 10+ times!

[illegible]

CHAPTER 13

Publishing Options for Kids

You can share your writing with the world TODAY! Options: school literary magazine, online writing communities (Wattpad, FanFiction.net), self-publishing (Amazon KDP), writing contests (Scholastic, Young Authors), starting a blog, making zines, or simply sharing with friends and family. Don't wait for permission to be a writer.

CHAPTER 13: WRITING EXERCISE

Write a book blurb (back cover summary) for a book YOU would want to read.

In 3-4 sentences, hook a reader. Don't give away the ending!

YOUR WRITING SPACE:

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CHAPTER 14

Author Habits

Professional writers have habits that help them produce consistently. They write at the same time daily. They set word count goals. They read A LOT. They carry notebooks everywhere. They don't wait for inspiration - they write even when they don't feel like it. Habits beat motivation every time!

CHAPTER 15

Your 30-Day Writing Challenge

For the next 30 days, write something every single day. It does not matter how short or messy. Just write! This challenge will build your writing muscle, fill your notebook with ideas, and prove that you CAN be a consistent writer. Day 1 starts TODAY. Ready?

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20 STORY STARTER PROMPTS

1. A door appears in your bedroom wall that wasn't there yesterday...
2. Write from the perspective of your pet for one day.
3. Two best friends discover they have the same recurring dream.
4. A kid finds a phone that can text anyone in history.
5. The last person on Earth gets a knock on the door.
6. You wake up and everyone speaks a language you don't know.
7. A tree in your backyard starts growing unusual fruit.
8. Write a story that takes place entirely in an elevator.
9. Your shadow starts acting independently.
10. A letter arrives addressed to you from the year 2075.
11. The school bully turns out to have a heartbreaking secret.
12. You can suddenly hear what animals are thinking.
13. A kid discovers their boring town has a hidden underground world.
14. Write a day in the life of your favorite object.
15. Two kids from enemy schools must work together on a project.
16. A magic notebook: anything written in it becomes true.
17. The new kid at school isn't from another city - they're from another dimension.
18. Write a story using only dialogue (no descriptions).
19. A kid's imaginary friend turns out to be real.
20. The weirdest substitute teacher ever walks into your classroom.

30-DAY WRITING CHALLENGE

- Day 1: [] Write about your morning in detail
- Day 2: [] Describe a stranger you saw today
- Day 3: [] Write dialogue between you and your future self
- Day 4: [] Poem: 5 things that are [color]
- Day 5: [] Rewrite a fairy tale in modern day
- Day 6: [] Write a letter to yourself 10 years from now
- Day 7: [] Story: a kid finds something unusual
- Day 8: [] Describe your favorite food to an alien
- Day 9: [] Write about your biggest fear
- Day 10: [] Flash fiction: tell a story in exactly 50 words
- Day 11: [] Write from the perspective of an old photograph
- Day 12: [] Describe a place you love without naming it
- Day 13: [] Write the worst day ever (fiction!)
- Day 14: [] Poem about a sound you heard today
- Day 15: [] Write about a time you were brave
- Day 16: [] Describe your best friend without using their name
- Day 17: [] Story opening: first line must be a question
- Day 18: [] Write directions to your house as adventure
- Day 19: [] What would you do with invisibility for 1 hour?
- Day 20: [] Write a scene set 100 years in the future
- Day 21: [] Letter to your favorite author
- Day 22: [] Describe the view from your window as a painting
- Day 23: [] Write a story where the last line is the title
- Day 24: [] Poem: what does silence look like?
- Day 25: [] Rewrite today as if it were the best day ever
- Day 26: [] Write about something you're grateful for (in detail!)
- Day 27: [] Story: two characters are stuck somewhere together
- Day 28: [] Write your own obituary at age 100 (imaginary life!)
- Day 29: [] Create a new holiday and describe how it's celebrated
- Day 30: [] Free write for 15 minutes. No stopping. No judging. Just write!

YOUNG AUTHOR CERTIFICATE

Awarded to:

For completing this entire book!

Date: _____

Author: Daniel Tesfamariam

[illegible]

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

[illegible]

Date: _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

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Free writing space:

[illegible]

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CHALLENGE:

Think of 3 new ideas related to this topic and explain each one.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Create a mind map connecting everything you learned.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Write a letter explaining this topic to a younger child.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Design a poster that teaches the most important concept.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

List 10 questions you still have about this topic.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

Draw a comic strip showing what you learned in action.

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Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Write 5 ways you can apply this knowledge in real life.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

Create a quiz for a friend (with answer key!).

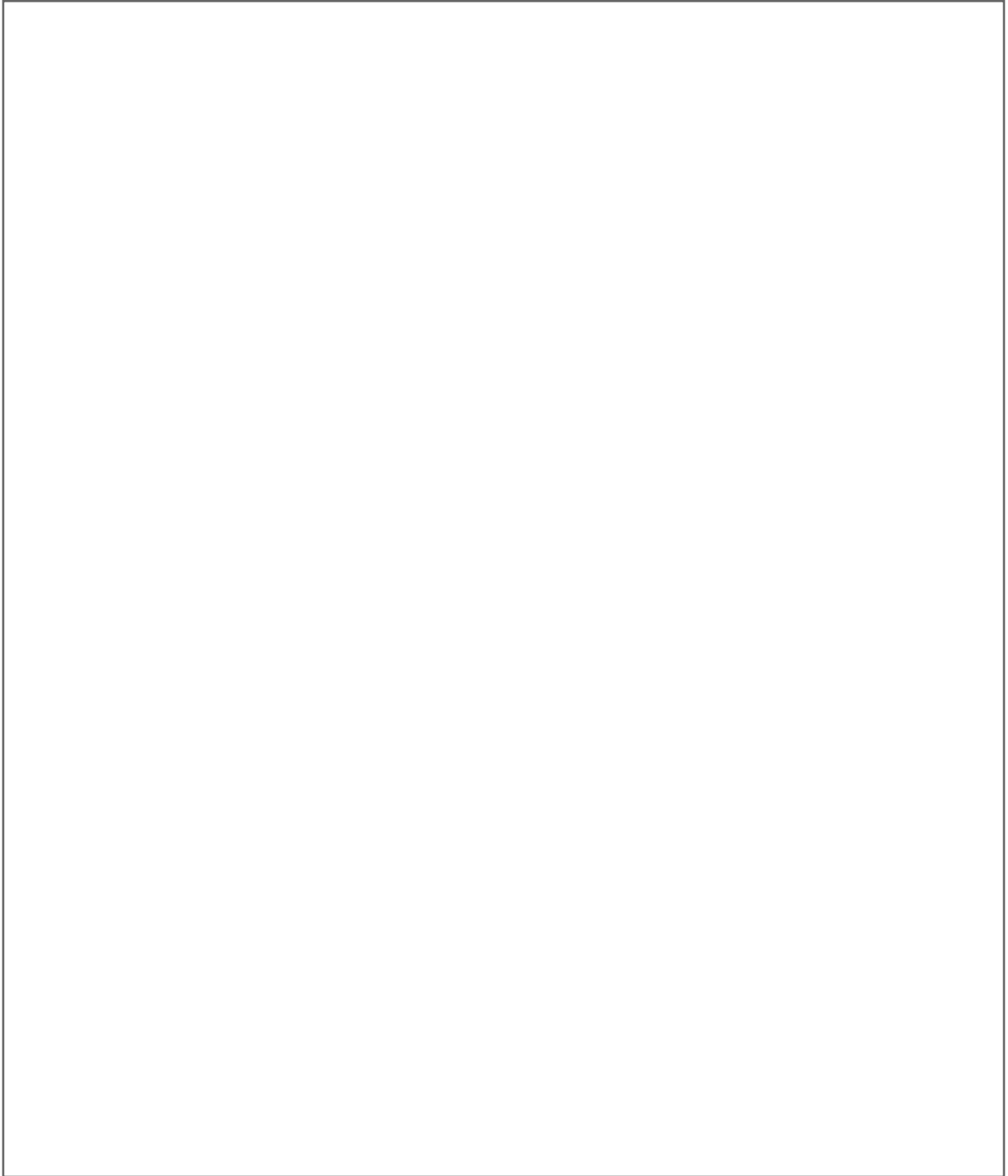
My Work:

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Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

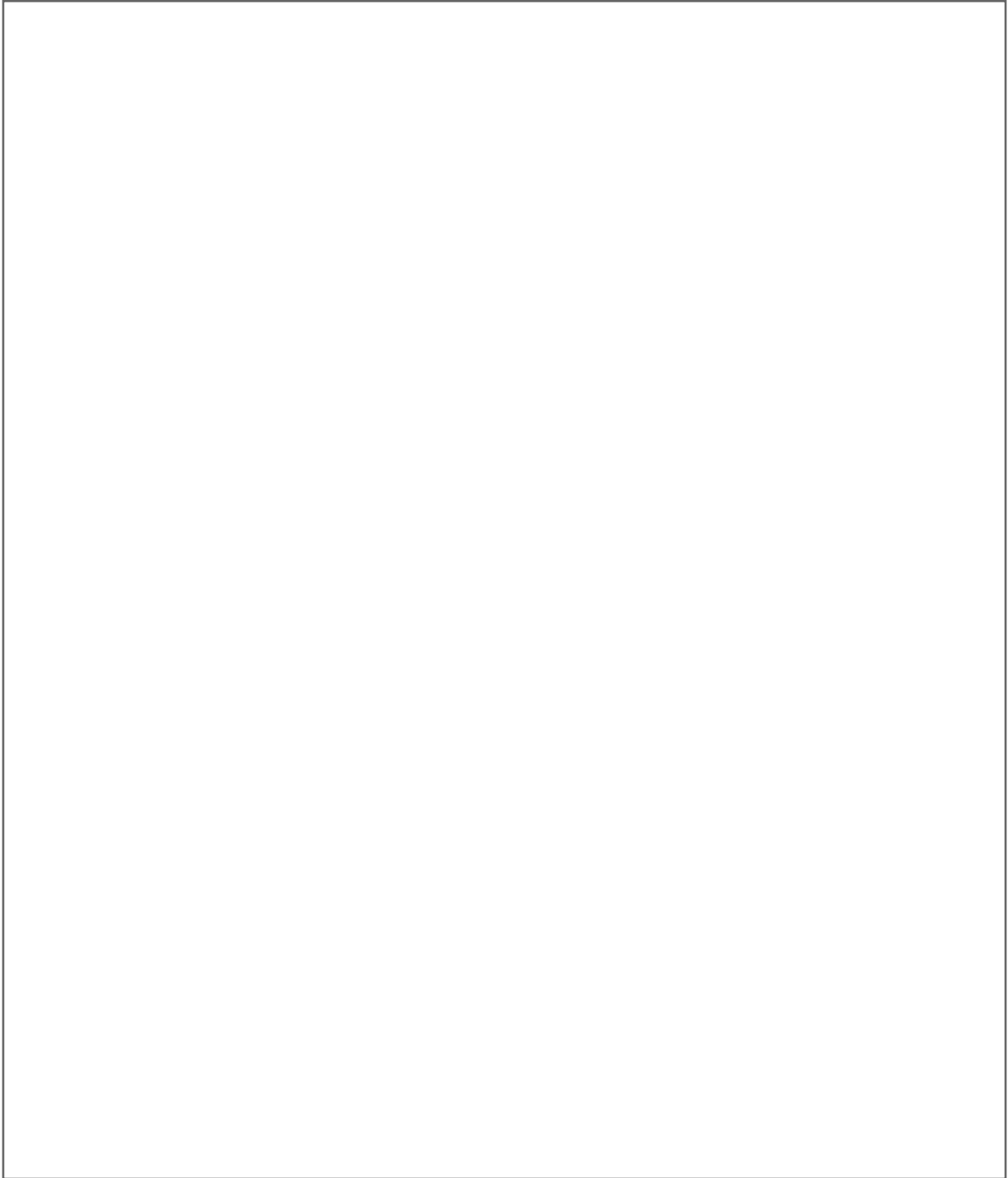
Draw what you learned today

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for creative expression, such as drawing, writing, or brainstorming.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

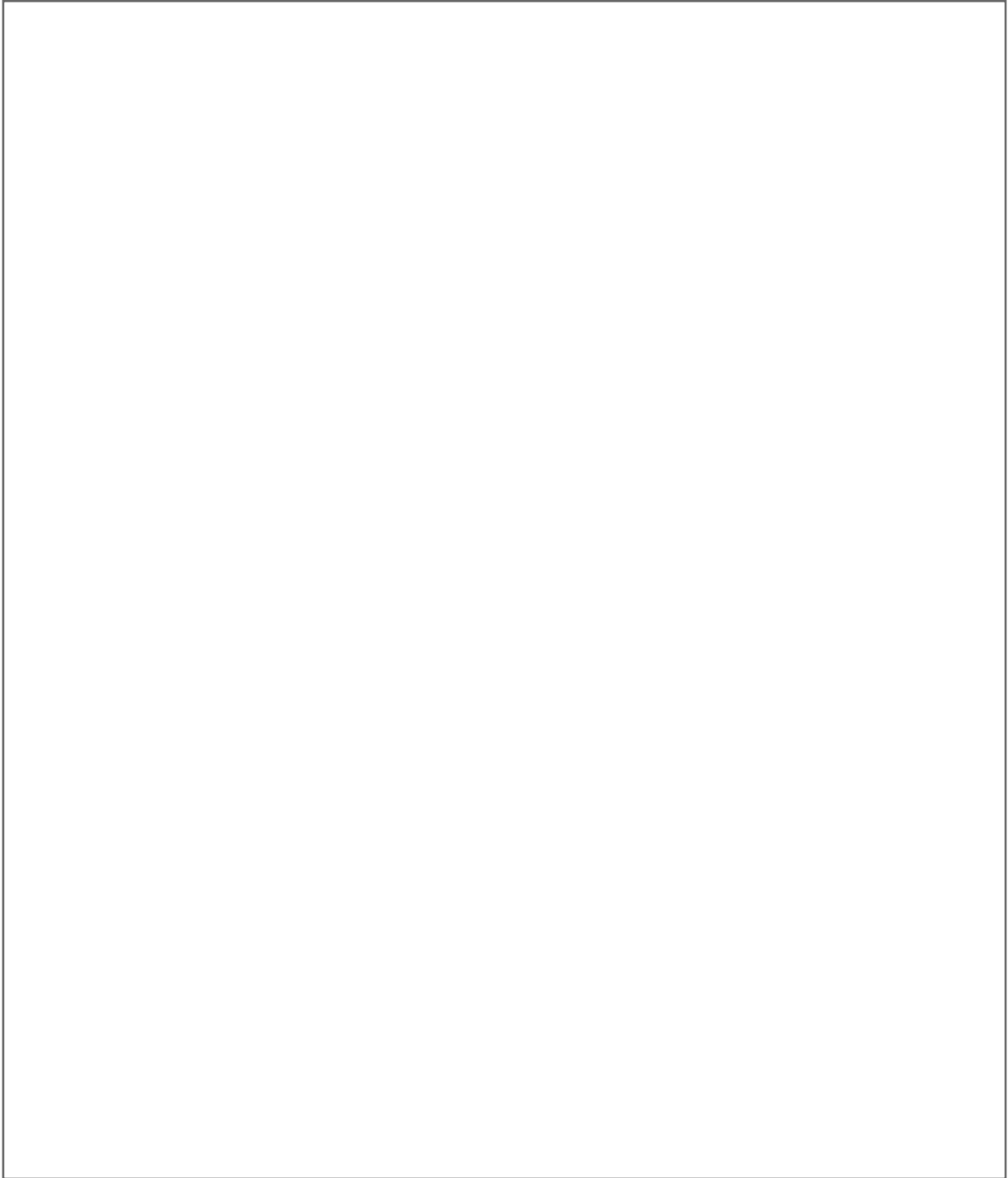
Illustrate your favorite concept

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for students to illustrate their favorite concept through drawing, writing, or brainstorming.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

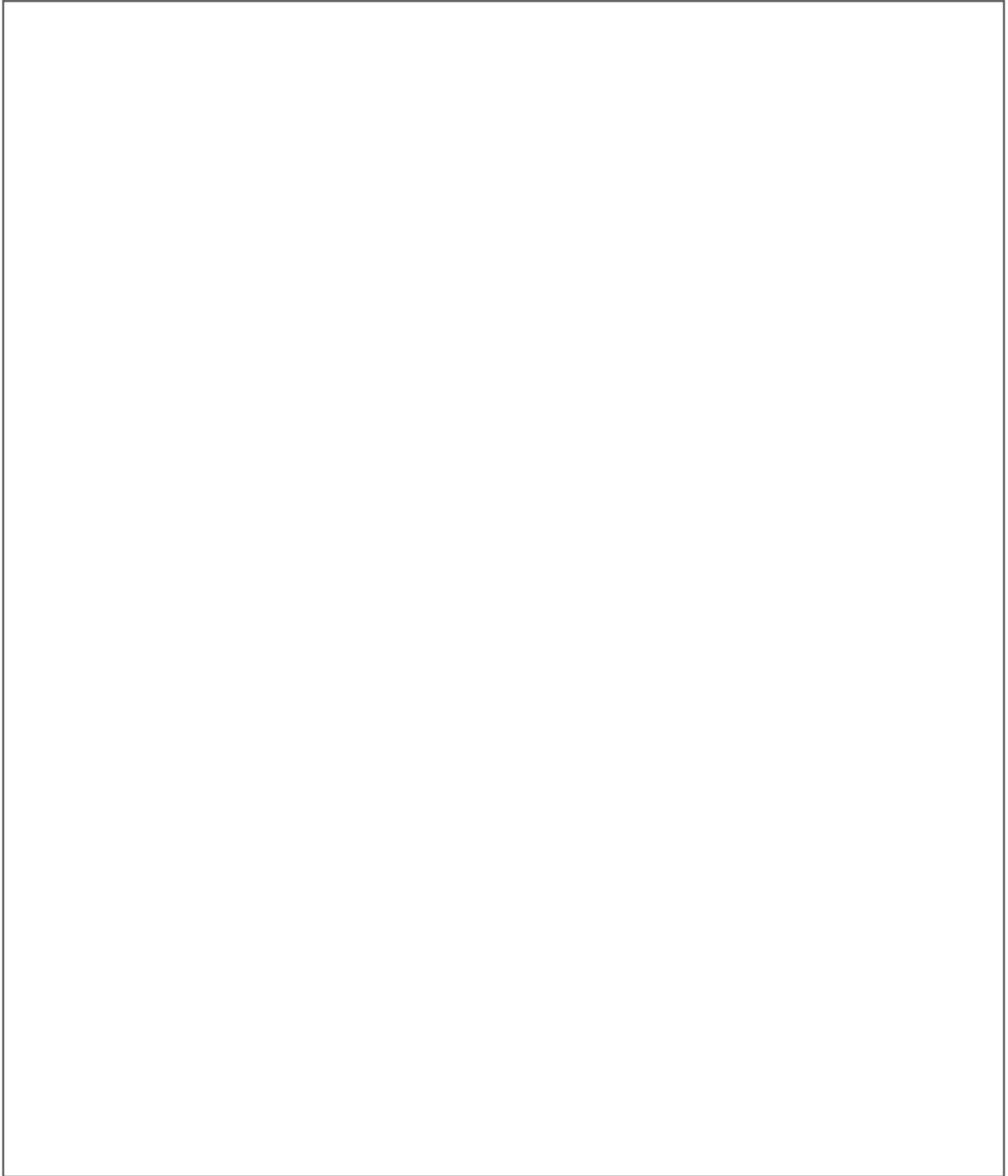
Create a visual summary of this chapter

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for a visual summary or creative writing.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

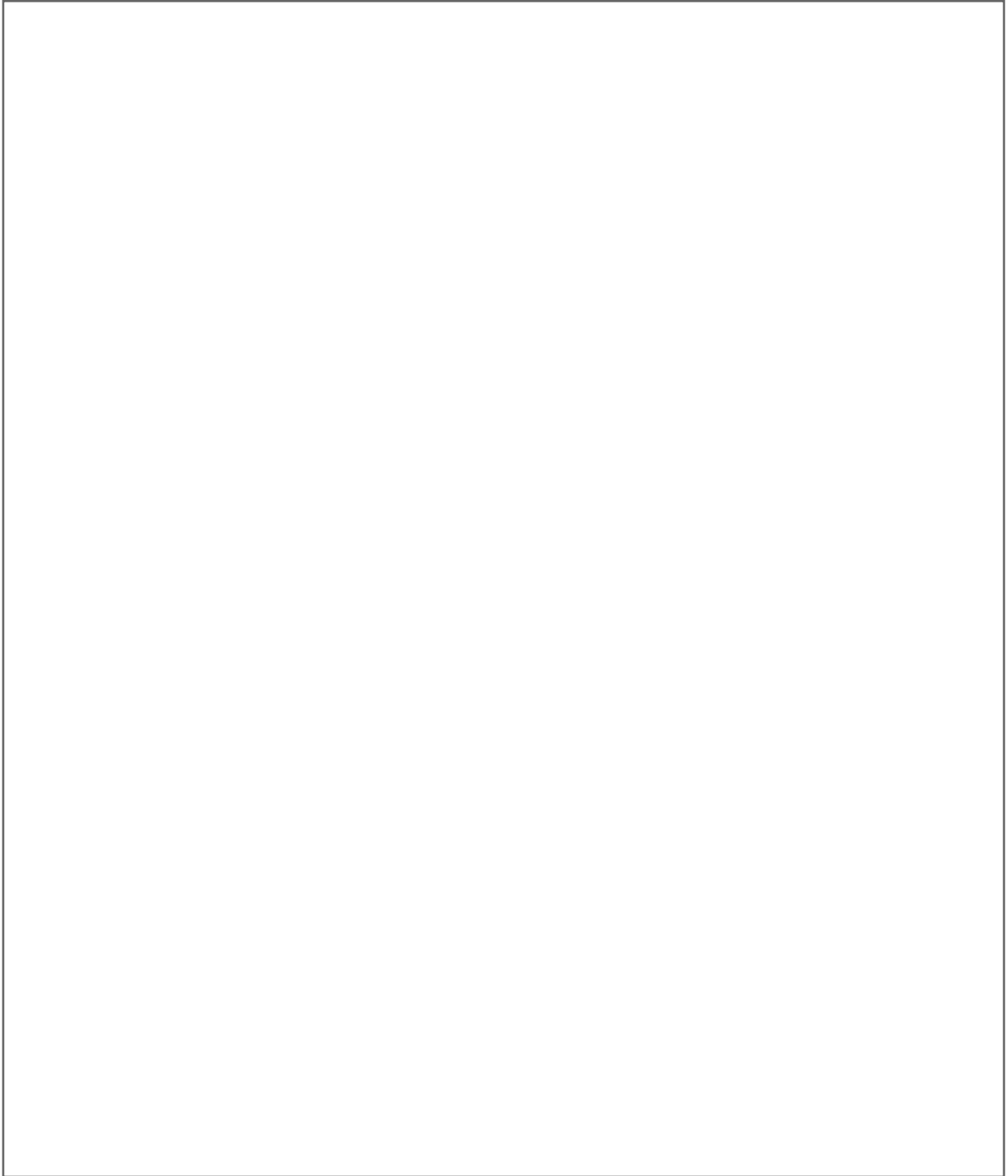
Draw yourself using this knowledge

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for creative writing, drawing, or brainstorming.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

Design a symbol that represents this topic

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for creative work such as drawing, writing, or brainstorming.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: WRITING

Sketch your goals

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for sketching goals, drawing, writing, or brainstorming.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

[illegible]

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across its entire width, providing a template for writing or drawing. The margins are consistent on all sides.

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across the entire width of the page, providing a guide for handwriting or typing. The background is a solid off-white color.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across the entire width of the page, providing a guide for writing. The background is a solid off-white color. There are no margins, text, or other markings present.

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[illegible]

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across its entire width, providing a guide for handwriting or typing. The background is a clean, solid white color.